

CRÈME ANGLAISE

INGREDIENTS

1160ml full cream milk
4 tsp pure vanilla extract with seeds
10 large free-range egg yolks
6 tbsp caster sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1

Put the milk in a medium saucepan with the vanilla pod and seeds and slowly bring just up to the boil. Set aside to infuse for 10 minutes. Remove the pod.

Step 2

In a mixing bowl, beat the egg yolks with the sugar using a wooden spoon until well combined. Pour in the infused milk, stirring constantly until well combined.

Step 3

Return the custard to the cleaned pan and heat gently, stirring, for about 5 minutes until it thickens and lightly coats the back of a spoon. Don't let it boil or the yolks will scramble (see tips).

Step 4

When the custard has reached the desired thickness, remove it from the heat and strain through a sieve into a medium bowl. Put a piece of cling film on the surface to prevent a skin forming and set aside or chill until ready to use.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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Moules Marinieres

Ingredients

2 tablespoons unsalted butter
1 small leek, white and light green parts only, thinly sliced
1 small shallot, thinly sliced
4 medium cloves garlic, thinly sliced
2 bay leaves
Coarse salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 cup hard dry cider or white wine
1kg mussels, cleaned
1 to 3 tablespoons heavy cream
1 tablespoon juice and 1 teaspoon grated zest from 1 lemon
3 tablespoons minced fresh parsley leaves
Additional homemade mayonnaise for serving (optional, see note above)
1 loaf rustic sourdough bread, thickly sliced, drizzled with olive oil, and broiled until heavily toasted

Method

Step 1:

Melt 1 tablespoon butter in a large saucepan over medium-low heat. Add leeks, shallot, garlic, and bay leave. Season lightly with salt and heavily with black pepper and cook, stirring, until vegetables are very soft but not browned, about 10 minutes.

Step 2:

Increase heat to high and add cider or wine. Bring to a boil and let reduce by half, about 2 minutes. Add mussels, stir, cover, and cook, shaking pan constantly and peeking every 30 seconds to stir. As soon as all the mussels are open, transfer mussels to a bowl using tongs. Place pan lid over bowl to keep mussels warm.

Step 3:

Remove from heat and whisk in remaining butter along with heavy cream. Return mussels to pot, add parsley, lemon juice, and lemon zest, stir to combine, then transfer to a warm serving bowl. Serve immediately.

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Classic Malva Pudding

Pudding:

60gms butter
1 cup white sugar
2 EXTRA LARGE eggs 2tbsp
apricot jam
2tsp bicarbonate of soda
1 cup milk
2 cups cake flour
Pinch of Salt
30ml vinegar

Sauce

250g butter
1 1/2 cups white sugar 1/2 cup water
1 1/2 cups cream
2 tsp vanilla essence

Instructions

Step 1

Cream butter and sugar together, beat in the egg until light and fluffy. Beat in the apricot jam.

Step 2

Dissolve the bicarb in the milk.

Step 3

Sift the flour and salt together and add to the creamed mixture alternately with the milk.
Lastly stir in the vinegar.

Step 4

Pour into a deep round dish about 19cm diameter. Cover the dish with a lid or foil and then bake for 1 hour at 180°C.

Sauce

Step 1

Bring the butter, sugar and water to the boil and simmer, stirring all the time for 2 minutes.

Step 2

Remove from the stove and then add the cream and the vanilla. Pour over the hot baked pudding.

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Spicey Chicken & Sundried Tomatoes

Ingredients:

1 tbsp. extra-virgin olive oil
5 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs
2 cloves garlic, minced
1 tbsp. fresh thyme leaves
1 tsp. crushed red pepper flakes
1 tsp sicilian orgeano
3/4 cup chicken broth
1/2 cup heavy cream
1/2 cup chopped sun-dried tomatoes
Kosher salt and black pepper
Fresh basil, for serving
Seasoned flour to dust chicken

Directions:

Step 1

Prepare seasoned flour.. In a large skillet over medium-high heat, heat oil. Dust chicken lightly in flour. Sear until golden and skin is crispy, 3 minutes per side. Transfer chicken to a plate and pour off half the fat.

Step 2

To skillet, add garlic, thyme, oregano and crushed red pepper flakes and let cook until fragrant, 1 minute. Add chicken broth, heavy cream, sun-dried tomatoes, and Parmesan and season with salt. Bring to a simmer, then return chicken to skillet and simmer covered, gently for 15 minutes, until chicken is fully cooked through.

Step 3

Garnish with basil and serve.

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WINTER MINESTRONE

INGREDIENTS

2 tablespoons olive oil
1 onion, chopped
2 carrots, peeled, chopped
2 celery ribs, chopped
90gms thinly sliced pancetta, coarsely chopped
2 garlic cloves, minced
450g swiss chard, stems trimmed, leaves coarsely chopped
1 russet potato, peeled, cubed
1 can diced tomatoes
1 fresh rosemary sprig
1 can cannellini beans, drained, rinsed
500ml beef broth
30g parmesan cheese, rind
2 tablespoons chopped fresh Italian parsley
salt and pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Heat the oil in a heavy large pot over medium heat. Add the onion, carrots, celery, pancetta, and garlic. Saute until the onion is translucent, about 10 minutes.

Step 2: Add the Swiss chard and potato; saute for 2 minutes. Add the tomatoes and rosemary sprig. Simmer until the chard is wilted and the tomatoes break down, about 10 minutes.

Step 3: Meanwhile, blend 3/4 cup of the beans with 1/4 cup of the broth in a processor until almost smooth. Add the pureed bean mixture, remaining broth, and Parmesan cheese rind to the vegetable mixture. Simmer until the potato pieces are tender, stirring occasionally, about 15 minutes.

Step 4: Stir in the whole beans and parsley. Simmer until the beans are heated through and the soup is thick, about 2 minutes. Season with salt and pepper, to taste. Discard Parmesan rind and rosemary sprig (the leaves will have fallen off of the stem.).

Step 5: Ladle the soup into bowls and serve..

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TRIPLE CHOC BROWNIES

INGREDIENTS

185g unsalted butter
185g best dark chocolate
85g plain flour
40g cocoa powder
50g white chocolate
50g milk chocolate
3 large eggs
275g golden caster sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Cut 185g unsalted butter into small cubes and tip into a medium bowl. Break 185g dark chocolate into small pieces and drop into the bowl.

Step 2: Fill a small saucepan about a quarter full with hot water, then sit the bowl on top so it rests on the rim of the pan, not touching the water. Put over a low heat until the butter and chocolate have melted, stirring occasionally to mix them.

Step 3: Remove the bowl from the pan and set aside to cool

Step 4: While you wait for the chocolate to cool, position a shelf in the middle of your oven and turn the oven on to 180C.

Step 5: Using a shallow 20cm square tin, cut out a square of non-stick baking parchment to line the base. Tip 85g plain flour and 40g cocoa powder into a sieve held over a medium bowl.

Step 6: Chop 50g white chocolate and 50g milk chocolate into chunks on a board.

Step 7: Break 3 large eggs into a large bowl and tip in 275g golden caster sugar. With an electric mixer on maximum speed, whisk the eggs and sugar. They will look thick and creamy, like a milk shake.

Step 8: Pour the cooled chocolate mixture over the egg mousse, then gently fold together with a rubber spatula, until the two mixtures are one and the colour is a mottled dark brown. The idea is to marry them without knocking out the air, so be as gentle and slow as you like.

Step 9: Resift the cocoa and flour mixture over the egg mixture and then gently fold in the flour, stop just before you feel you should, as you don't want to overdo this mixing.

Step 10: Finally, stir in the white and milk chocolate chunks until they're dotted throughout.

Step 11: Pour the mixture into the prepared tin, scraping every bit out of the bowl with the spatula. Gently ease the mixture into the corners of the tin and paddle the spatula from side to side across the top to level it.

Step 12: Put in the oven and set your timer for 25 mins. When the buzzer goes, open the oven, pull the shelf out a bit and gently shake the tin. If the brownie wobbles in the middle, it's not quite done, so slide it back in and bake for another 5 minutes until the top has a shiny, papery crust and the sides are just beginning to come away from the tin. Take out of the oven and allow to cool completely before removing from the tin and cutting into squares.

THE COOKERY

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Avgolemeno

Ingredients

Extra Virgin Olive Oil (I used Private Reserve Greek olive oil)

½ to 1 cup finely chopped carrots

½ to 1 cup finely chopped celery

½ to 1 cup finely chopped green onions

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

8 cups low-sodium chicken broth

2 bay leaves

1 cup rice

Salt and pepper

2 cooked boneless chicken breast pieces, shredded (about 6 to 8 oz store-bought rotisserie chicken will work)

½ cup freshly-squeezed lemon juice

2 large eggs

Fresh parsley for garnish (optional)

Method

Step 1:

In a large Dutch oven or heavy pot, heat 1 tbsp olive oil on medium-high. Add the carrots, celery and green onions, toss together to saute briefly then stir in the garlic.

Step 2:

Add the chicken broth and bay leaves then raise the heat to high. Once the liquid has come to a rolling boil, add the rice, salt and pepper.

Step 3:

Turn the heat to medium-low and simmer for 20 minutes or until the rice is tender. Now stir in the cooked chicken.

Step 4:

To prepare the egg-lemon sauce, in a medium bowl, whisk together the lemon juice and eggs. While whisking add 2 ladles-full of the broth from the cooking pot (this helps temper the eggs). Once fully combined, add the sauce to the chicken soup and stir. Remove from the heat immediately.

Step 5:

Garnish with fresh parsley, if you like. Serve hot with your favorite bread. Enjoy!

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Swedish Meatballs

Sometimes called Ikea meatballs are a delicious, simple and warming supper

Ingredients

2 slices white sandwich bread , crusts removed, chopped into small cubes
1 onion , small (brown, white or yellow)
300g minced beef
300g ground pork, or sub with more beef
1 egg
1/4 tsp ground nutmeg , preferably freshly grated
1/4 tsp All Spice powder
1/4 tsp black pepper
3/4 tsp salt
1 tbsp oil

GRAVY

40g / 3 tbsp butter , unsalted 3 tbsp flour
2 cups beef broth/stock (salt reduced), or sub with chicken
1/2 cup heavy / thickened cream

Method

Step 1: Grate onion using a standard box grater. Scrape onion and juices into bowl. Add bread and mix well - onion juice should make bread soggy (if not, add a tiny splash of milk). Set aside to soak for 1 minute.

Step 2: Add remaining Meatball ingredients EXCEPT oil. Mix well. Using a tablespoon measure and measure out a heaped tablespoon (or use ice cream scooper which is what I do), dollop on work surface. Repeat with remaining mixture: 25 - 30 meatballs. Then roll into shape.

COOKING

Step 1: Heat 1 tbsp oil in a skillet over medium high heat. Add half the meatballs and brown all over (but raw inside still) - about 3 minutes. Remove onto plate, then brown the remaining batch.

If there is lots of oil, pour off excess and discard. Lower heat to medium.

GRAVY

Step 1: Add butter into skillet and melt. Add flour and stir in. Cook for 1 minute.

Step 2: While mixing, add about 1/4 of the beef broth - it will thicken quickly. Then gradually add remaining beef broth, stirring as you go. Switch to whisk if required to make it lump free. When the liquid is simmering, add meatball and juices pooled on plate.

Step 3: Turn up heat slightly to keep it at a rapid simmer. Cook for 8 - 10 minutes or until the liquid thickens into a thin gravy, stirring occasionally.

Step 4:

Add cream, simmer for a further 2 minutes then remove from stove and serve.

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GORGONZOLA & PANCETTA MAC N CHEESE

INGREDIENTS

240g short-cut pasta
kosher salt and freshly-ground black pepper
½ cup Panko breadcrumbs
¼ cup plus 2 tablespoons Parmesan cheese, divided
½ cup crumbled Blue Cheese
2 cups shredded Fontina
1/2 cup half and half
2 cups whole milk
3 tablespoons all purpose flour
1 large leek (white and light green parts only), washed thoroughly and cut into thin slices
120g diced pancetta
5 tablespoons unsalted butter , divided, plus additional for buttering ramekins or baking dish
chopped parsley or snipped chives , for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Preheat oven to 200C with rack in middle position. Butter a baking dish, or six. Place on a baking sheet and set aside.

Step 2: Mix Panko, 1 tablespoon melted butter, 2 tablespoons Parmesan, and a pinch of salt and pepper in a small bowl. Set aside.

Step 3: Cook pasta to "al-dente" in a large pot of salted boiling water. Reserve 1 cup of the pasta water before draining well.

Step 4: While bringing your pasta water to a boil, melt 4 tablespoons of butter in a large, heavy-bottomed pot until foaming subsides. Add pancetta and cook over medium-high heat until fat is rendered and pancetta is just beginning to crisp.

Step 5: Add leeks, ½ teaspoon each kosher salt and black pepper to the pot. Cook until leeks are softened, about 5 minutes. Reduce heat and continue cooking, stirring often, until leeks are very soft and caramelized, about 15 minutes longer. Stir in flour and cook for 1 minute. Add milk and cream, stirring until sauce is smooth and thickened, about 3 minutes. Whisk in Fontina, Gorgonzola, and ¼ cup Parmesan. Season to taste with additional salt and pepper.

Step 6: Add cooked pasta to the cheese sauce, stirring until well combined. Stir in enough pasta water to make the sauce creamy, but not thin and watery (I usually add about ¼ cup). Transfer pasta to prepared baking dishes and top with breadcrumb mixture.

Step 7: Bake 15-20 minutes, until sauce is bubbly and breadcrumbs are toasted. Sprinkle with parsley or chives, if desired, and serve hot.

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GARLIC & MINT ZUCCHINI

2 courgettes (zucchini)
2 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil
1 garlic clove, (peeled but not sliced)
1 handful fresh mint
juice of ¼ lemon
salt and pepper, to taste

Instructions

Step 1: First, cut the zucchini into 3cm x .5cm batons.

[Optional pre-salting the zucchini - Place the zucchini batons in a colander set over a bowl and liberally sprinkle salt over them. Quickly mix the salt into the courgettes with your hands and leave for 5-10 minutes so that the salt can draw out the juices from the courgette. Once the batons look wet and glistening, rinse them under the tap in the colander to wash away all the salt and any juices. Then dry in a clean tea towel or kitchen towel.]

Step 2: In the meantime, slice the fresh mint thinly.

Step 3: Heat the oil in a large frying pan over a medium heat. Once hot, add the whole garlic clove and move around in the pan to brown on all sides and flavour the oil. Once browned, remove from the pan and discard (or use to flavour in something else).

Step 4: Add the courgette batons in one single layer. Do not overlap the batons. You may need to sauté the courgette batons in batches. Sauté the courgette batons until the underside is golden brown (about 2-4 minutes), then, using a pair of kitchen tongs, turn each slice over to cook on all the other side. Cook until golden brown on all sides.

Step 5: Once cooked, add the chopped mint and a squeeze of lemon juice and stir over the heat for 30 seconds until the mint has wilted and the lemon juice is mixed into the courgette batons. (If cooking in batches, add the pre-cooked slices back into the pan at this point and stir all together over the heat). Season with salt and pepper to your taste. Serve hot.

THE COOKERY

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Green Beans & Tomatoes

Ingredients

300g rip fresh tomatoes
500g fine green beans
2 garlic cloves
2 tbsp fresh basil leaves
Extra virgin olive oil as needed

Method

Step 1

Skin the tomatoes and the cut in half removing the seeds and juice.

Step 2

Trim the stalk end from the green beans, peel and finely slice the garlic.

Step 3

Heat 2 tbsp olive oil in a thick bottomed pan, and lightly brow the garlic. Add the tomatoes, season, cover and cook for 15-minutes on a medium heat.

Step 4

Boil the beans in well salted water until just soft about 7-10 minutes. Drain then stir into the tomato sauce.

Step 5

Season with salt & pepper, drizzle with olive oil and the roughly torn basil leaves and serve.

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RISOTTO RUSTICO DELLA TRADIZIONE TOSCANE

Ingredients

For the Meat Sauce

100 g minced meat
200g chicken livers
50 ml red wine (1 glass)
40 g butter
35 extra virgin olive oil
2 tablespoons tomato paste
55 g red onion
60 g carrot
25 g celery
12 g fine salt
Generous Crack of black pepper

For the Risotto

360 g Carnaroli rice (Aquerello)
10 g butter
55 g red onioncon
1 l meat broth
40 g Parmigiano Reggiano DOP
2tbsp Finely chopped flat leaf parsley

Method

For the Meat Sauce

Step 1: Let's start preparing the sauce by cleaning and washing the vegetables, put them in the blender or chop them with the mezzaluna, the mince must be a little coarse, but not rough.

Step 2: Place three tablespoons of extra virgin olive oil in the pan, then place it on medium heat. Wash the liver well with water and place it in water and wine vinegar while the vegetables are browning ; this is to remove some of its flavor that not everyone loves. Brown the soffrito and then add the minced meat and the rinsed chicken liver and the spoons of tomato preserve diluted in a ladle of hot broth. At this point you can salt the meat.

Step 3: Continue cooking slowly and covered, for about 40 minutes, with a glass of red wine and, if this is not enough, adding a little broth.

Step 4: For the last 10 minutes, uncover the pot to thicken the sauce, break up the liver with a fork and mix it all together.

Step 5: Now prepare the risotto, by placing the butter in a saucepan and adding the finely chopped onion.

Step 6: When the browning process is finished, add the rice and toast for two minutes, stirring constantly with a wooden ladle. Start by adding, little by little, the very hot meat broth, stirring often and keeping the flame on medium heat.

Step 7: Bring the rice up slowly, adding the broth little by little and letting it absorb before adding more.

Step 8: Once you have reached two thirds of the cooking time, add about half of the meat sauce, which must be hot. When the rice is cooked, taste for salt and adjust if necessary.

Step 9: Stir in the grated parmesan. Serve hot and, on top of the risotto, put two good spoonfuls of the meat sauce. Sprinkle with freshly ground pepper. It will also be delicious with an aromatic pepper.

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Lamb Ragu

Ingredients

500gms lamb shoulder meat, cut into small cubes
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
2 shallots, quartered
Sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 sprig rosemary
2 sprigs thyme
1 bay leaf
1 small white onion, chopped
1 cup dry red wine
2 cups tomato sauce
1 sprig fresh basil, chopped
500gms pasta
½ cup grated aged Pecorino Sardo cheese (or
other pecorino cheese)

Instructions

Step 1

Chop the meat into small cubes and set aside.

Step 2

In a medium saucepan, heat the olive oil, shallots, thyme, and rosemary over medium heat.

Step 3

Add the chopped meat to the saucepan and simmer for 2 minutes. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Add the bay leaf and onion. Saute for 5 minutes, until meat has browned.

Step 4

Add wine, stirring frequently, and deglaze, scraping browned bits from bottom of the pan. Add tomato sauce and basil. Let simmer on low heat for 15 minutes. (Add lamb or vegetable stock if sauce becomes dry.)

Step 5

Cook for another 15 minutes until the lamb cubes are tender.

Step 6

Add to the pasta at the same time stirring in the grated cheese.

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Broccoli, Ricotta Bruschetta

A simple rustic bruschetta

Serves: 4

Prep Time: 15 mins

Cook Time: 10 mins

Ingredients:

Knob of butter

4tbsp extra virgin olive oil 120gms broccoli

1 clove garlic

pinch dried chilli 100gms ricotta cheese parmesan shavings

salt & pepper

12 slices of baguette extra virgin olive oil

1 clove garlic

Directions:

Bring some salted water to the boil. Cook the broccoli for 2-minutes until starting to go tender. Drain and set aside. In a frying pan heat the olive oil and knob of butter, then add the finely sliced garlic and the dried chilli. As soon as the garlic begins to brown add the broccoli to the pan and pan fry for 2-3 minutes.

To prepare the ricotta season fresh ricotta with salt and pepper and a drizzle of extra virgin olive oil.

Toast the bruschetta in a hot pan and then rub with cut clove of garlic and drizzle with olive oil.

To serve top the bruschetta with some ricotta cheese and pile on some hot broccoli, top with parmesan shavings.

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Polenta (Gucci Pap)

Serve with the Cacciatore

Ingredients:

500gms polenta
2 cloves garlic
1,2 litre water
500ml full cream milk
50gms salted butter
200gms grated parmesan
Salt & Pepper for seasoning

Directions:

Heat the milk, water and the crushed garlic until almost hot, add 1 tsp salt and some pepper. Then stir in the polenta and bring to a slow simmer (be careful it can splash)

After 3-minutes stir in 3/4 of the milk, the butter and parmesan. Check consistency, if too thick add more milk until you have your desired consistency.

Check seasoning again and serve warm with chicken cacciatore.

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Beetroot Gnocchi

Ingredients

1 kg floury potatoes, boiled
400g roasted beetroot, peeled and roughly chopped
300g plain flour
1 free-range egg, lightly beaten
pinch salt

Blue Cheese Pancetta Sauce

Half cup blue cheese
Cup cream
80g pancetta
60ml white wine (optional)

Method

Step 1

Place potatoes through a potato ricer (or mash them by fork) onto a floured surface

Step 2

Place the roasted beetroot into a food processor and blend until smooth. If necessary, run the puree through a sieve

Step 3

Gently mix the beetroot puree into the potatoes, and make a well from the mixture. Then add beaten egg as well as pinch of salt, and half the flour to the mixture.

Step 4

Gently start folding the mixture into itself (do NOT OVERWORK), gradually adding the balance of the flour (eventually bringing the dough into a ball)

Step 5

Split the dough into smaller size balls, and gently start rolling them out into 1cm thick ropes. Cut at 1-2cm intervals and transfer gnocchi to a floured baking tray. To cook - add to rapidly boiling salted water. Remove when floating and transfer to blue cheese sauce.

To prepare the sauce:

In a frying pan, over medium heat, add the pancetta and fry until it has rendered and started to release its oils. If using wine add at this stage and cook until the wine has reduced to a syrup. Now add the cream and the blue cheese cook over a medium heat until the blue cheese has melted, - switch off the heat

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PEAR, GOATS CHEESE & BABY SPINACH SALAD

INGREDIENTS

Cooked pears

2 large pears cored and sliced lengthwise

3 tablespoons olive oil divided

¼ cup honey

3 tablespoons freshly squeezed lemon juice

Salad ingredients

5 oz baby spinach

1 cup pecan halves toasted, chopped

150g goat cheese

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Core the pears and slice each one length-wise. You don't need to peel them.

Step 2: Heat 2 tablespoons of olive oil in a large skillet on medium-high heat.

Step 3: Add sliced pears and cook them for about 3 minutes per side or until soft and pliable. Remove from heat.

Step 4: Add honey, lemon juice, and another tablespoon of olive oil and stir everything together.

Step 5: Toast your pecan halves in a pan and set aside to cool

Assembly

Step 1: Combine all the salad ingredients (except pecans) in a large serving bowl, including cooked pears and all the juices from the skillet, and toss to combine. Then, top the salad with chopped toasted pecan halves.

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Penne alla Norma

Ingredients

700gms eggplant
Olive oil as needed (at least 1/2 cup)
Salt and pepper
1 tablespoon chopped garlic
3 or 4 dried chiles
1 ½ pounds tomatoes, chopped (canned are fine; about 1 can)
1 teaspoon good dried oregano, or 1 tablespoon fresh
1 pound long pasta
½ cup chopped parsley or basil

Directions

Step 1

Slice the eggplant about 1.5cm thick. Cook in abundant olive oil, without crowding, sprinkling with salt and adding more oil as needed. You will undoubtedly have to cook in batches; take your time and cook until the eggplant is nicely browned and soft. Remove to a plate; do not drain on paper towels.

Step 2

Meanwhile, put a large pot of water to boil and salt it.

Step 3

At the end of the cooking the eggplant, the pan will ideally have a couple of tablespoons of oil left. If there's more or less, drain some off or add a bit. Turn the heat to medium, add the garlic and chiles, and cook until the garlic colors a little bit.

Step 4

Add the tomatoes and oregano, along with some salt and pepper; cook until saucy but not too dry, stirring occasionally.

Step 5

Cook the pasta until al dente. While it's cooking, cut the eggplant into strips and reheat for a minute in the tomato sauce. Drain the pasta and toss it with the tomato sauce and the eggplant. Taste and adjust the seasoning, then top with the parsley or basil and serve.

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Spanakopita

1 kg. fresh spinach, washed, dried, trimmed, and coarsely chopped
3 Tbs. extra-virgin olive oil
1 bunch scallions (about 3 oz. or 10 small), white and light-green parts only, trimmed and finely chopped
2 cups crumbled feta cheese (10 oz.)
1/2 cup finely grated Greek kefalotyri cheese or Parmigiano-Reggiano
2 large eggs, lightly beaten
1/2 cup finely chopped fresh dill
1/3 cup finely chopped fresh flat-leaf parsley
1/4 tsp. freshly grated nutmeg
Kosher or fine sea salt

For the assembly:

1/3 cup extra-virgin olive oil for brushing; more as needed
Eighteen 9x14-inch sheets frozen phyllo dough, thawed and at room temperature 2 tsp. milk

TIP:

Phyllo dries out very fast and becomes brittle when exposed to the air. Check out our test kitchen tips for working with it. Position a rack in the center of the oven and heat the oven to 375°F.

Make the filling: Heat a 10-inch straight-sided saute pan over medium-high heat. Add a few large handfuls of the spinach and cook, tossing gently with tongs. As the spinach starts to wilt, add the rest a few handfuls at a time. Cook until all the spinach is wilted and bright green, about 4 minutes. With a slotted spoon, transfer the spinach to a colander set in a sink. Let cool slightly and squeeze with your hands to extract as much of the remaining liquid as you can.

Wipe the pan dry with a paper towel. Heat the oil in the pan over medium heat. Add the scallions and cook until soft and fragrant, about 4 minutes. Stir in the spinach, turn off the heat, and let cool for 5 minutes. Then stir in the cheeses, eggs, dill, parsley, nutmeg, and 1/2 tsp. salt and mix thoroughly.

Assemble the pie: With a pastry brush, lightly coat the bottom and sides of a 9x13x2-inch baking pan with some of the oil. Working quickly, lightly oil one side of a phyllo sheet and lay it in the pan oiled side up and off center so that it partially covers the bottom and reaches halfway up one long side of the pan (the edge on the bottom of the pan will be about 1 inch from the side). Lightly oil the top of another phyllo sheet and lay it oiled side up and off center so it reaches halfway up the other long side of the pan. (If your pan has sloped sides, the sheets may be slightly longer than the bottom of the pan; if so, let the excess go up one short side of the pan and then alternate with subsequent sheets.) Repeat this pattern with 4 more phyllo sheets.

Next, lightly oil the tops of 3 phyllo sheets and layer them oiled side up and centered in the pan. Spread the filling evenly over the last layer.

Repeat the oiling and layering of the remaining 9 phyllo sheets over the filling in the same way you layered the previous 9. With the oiled bristles of the pastry brush, push the edges of the phyllo down around the sides of the pan to enclose the filling completely.

With a sharp knife, score the top phyllo layer into 24 rectangles, being careful not to cut all the way through to the filling. Using the same pastry brush, brush the milk along all the score marks (this will keep the phyllo from flaking up along the edges of the squares). Bake the spanakopita until the top crust is golden brown, 35 to 45 minutes. Let cool until just warm. Cut out the rectangles carefully along the score marks and serve.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

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